



THE **7** FUNDRAISING HABITS OF HIGHLY EFFECTIVE SHLUCHIM

Contributing Shluchim: **Rabbi Mendy Herson, Rabbi Shraga Sherman, Rabbi Heshy Epstein**

[ו...]בהוספה לזה יודע השליח אודות שכרו בצדו, וזה נותן תענוג בעבודתו – שפעולותיו הפרטיות במקום המסויים, עוזרים לכלל ישראל ומביאים את הגאולה [כפס"ד הרמב"ם (הל' תשובה פ"ג ה"ד), שע"י "מצוה אחת כר הכריע את עצמו ואת כל העולם כולו לכף זכות וגרם לו ולהם תשועה והצלה"]. אבל לזה אסור לבלבל במילוי השליחות פרטית במקום המסויים עם תושבי המקום.

–התועודיות תשמ"ז ח"א עמ' 645

לכל לראש עושה השליח - ובאופן דכל מעייני בו - בשליחות הפרטית במקום המסויים עם תושבי המקום המסויים, ע"י שהוא נוטע בהם את ההתעניינות באמת במצב הפרטי של תושבי המקום, אנשים נשים וטף, ומחפש יחד אתם את הדרכים כיצד ניתן לעזור בעניינים שלהם, ולהפיץ יהדות וחסידות, וצדק ויושר בכלל.

A shliach goes about his task of igniting individual souls with the end goal always in sight. Whether he's taking the time to speak with a child or running a program for hundreds of people, he knows that it's all part of the greater effort to fulfill his shlichus. This shlichus involves many different kinds of tasks, including the process of raising the funds to make it happen.

Like all other aspects of shlichus, when it comes to fundraising we turn to Torah sources as well as tried and proven methods from the world at large. These resources give us the techniques to go about our work in the most efficient way possible. Here, we take a look at a well regarded and valuable book – *The 7 Habits of Highly Effective People* – and present it with a Chassidishe ta'am and actual experiences of shluchim.

Fundraising, in contemporary thought, is often reduced to a medium of monetary solicitation for a particular organization. However, fundraising for shlichus encompasses a deeper dimension. As **Rabbi Mendy Herson** of Basking Ridge, NJ puts it, "The primary currency in fundraising is relationships."

In fact, the Hebrew word for fund is קרן, which means principal. Principal is an asset, and assets scale three basic categories: physical, financial, and human. In shlichus, fundraising is as much about the human aspect as it is about the financial and physical aspects.

Rabbi Shraga Sherman in Merion Station, PA relates: "There is never a time that I am not fundraising, but I am not always asking for money." Instead, Rabbi Sherman focuses his energies on developing real friendships that extend far beyond the parameters of finances. "When you are conscious of who is in your circle of friends and work on the maintenance of those relationships, the funds come as a natural extension because they are true partners in your work."

Fundraising on shlichus is about outreach. The task of gathering resources which are capable of funding an initiative to reach every Jew is thoroughly interwoven with the mission to reach the Yid and make him aware of his Jewish-

ness. How does a shliach find the courage to boldly ask, "Excuse me, are you Jewish?" but when it comes to asking for a donation he is suddenly conquered by shyness, resistance, and avoidance?

This article doesn't seek to answer this question but to negate its very existence. Based on the 7 Habits, we present fundraising for shlichus as the metamorphosis from an independent mentality to habitual interdependence. The idea is to view fundraising as a vital role in your shlichus and not as a subordinate task. These are the time-tested principles that lead to growth and success.

Mark Twain once attended a meeting at which a speaker was raising money. Twain, deeming the cause to be a worthy one, decided to donate \$100. As the speaker droned on, however, he decided to cut his contribution in half.

With no end in sight, Twain cut his intended offer again, to \$10. At last the speaker finished and the collection basket was passed around.

Twain's contribution? When the basket finally reached him, he removed a dollar and passed it along.

The story demonstrates that while you may have a worthy cause, and even an interested and contributing audience, the relationship remains the pillar that fundraising is built on. Without it, the contributory factor disappears and all the Mark Twains can be lost. In fundraising it is essential to find the right balance of communication and at times supplement speaking with the fine attribute of listening.

Rabbi Heshy Epstein, Shliach in Columbia, SC, associates fundraising with "building relationships with others, selling your vision, your dream, inspiring them, and empowering them to feel like

they are your partners." In order to do this, monitoring feedback is crucial. "Listen to their interests. Ask them what they think the community needs."

Fundraising is not an event, but the process of obtaining resources that will fuel the engine of growth your Chabad House needs. The "asking" part of fundraising, the most delicate part of the process, stands as the bridge between two partners or friends. To get to the "asking" point, you must listen to the telltale signs of a partnership established and a friendship earned.

Adopt these seven habits into your repertoire of outreach so you may start raising "principal" in more than just one sense.

Habit 1 Be Proactive

Your life doesn't just "happen." At every moment you have the choice to be happy or sad. Decisive or ambivalent. Courageous or fearful. Each new situation provides the perfect opportunity to do things differently, to produce more positive results.

At the dawn of our nation, Hashem tells Avraham, "Go from your land (environment), from your birthplace (psyche) and from your father's house (genetic disposition)." Go out of that which limits you. The way you deal with the world must be shaped by your shlichus, and not by external conditions.

When obstacles come up, the focus must be on figuring out what you *can* do, instead of reacting to or worrying about conditions over which you have little or no control. Even better, preempt the obstacles by being ready for them: Reactive shluchim fundraise when they lack funds. Proactive shluchim sow the seeds of fundraising that will fund their future endeavors. They take initiative and remember that המעשה הוא העיקר.

In the paradigm of shlichus, one can transcend all limitations with the kochoh the Rebbe imparts. ראה אנכי נתתי לפניכם היום – when you understand that the משיח is giving you this shlichus today, you realize that everything is possible. You can be more resourceful, you can be more diligent and you can be more creative.

לכתחילה אריבער!

Habit 2 Begin with the End in Mind

We may be very busy, we may be very efficient; but we will only be effective when we begin with the end in mind.

Think of it this way: Where do you want your Chabad House to be when Moshiach comes?

Using this question as a guide, create a personal mission statement for your shlichus. Determine what you want to be and do for your community. Take the time to envision in your mind what you cannot at present see with your eyes. If you don't make a conscious effort to visualize who you are and what you want in your shlichus, then you empower other people and circumstances to shape your life.

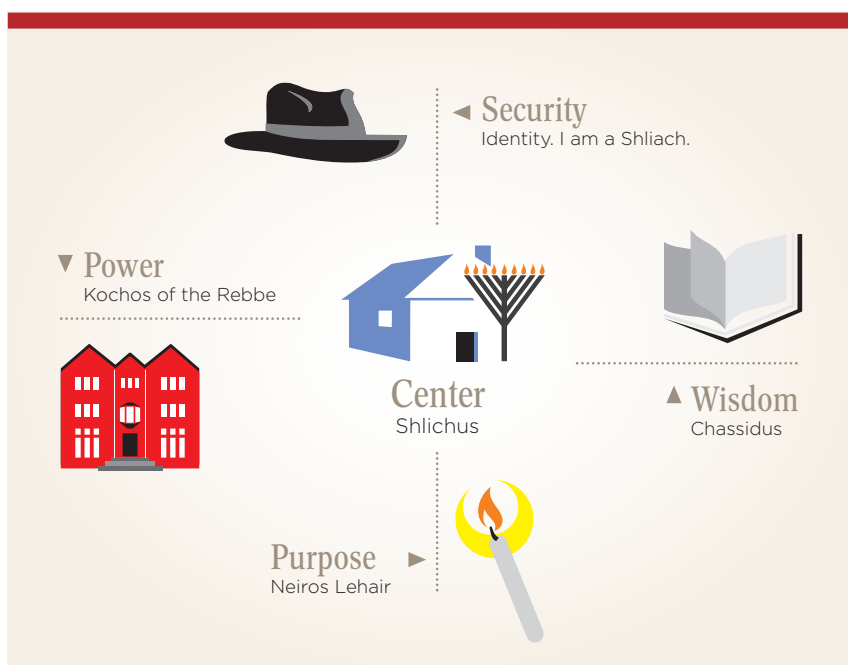
Creating a mission statement gives you a sense of security in your shlichus. Nothing will be able to knock you off your course. When you are secure in who you are as a shliach and know that your unique purpose is to be a נר להאיר, then you more clearly understand the wisdom of Chassidus and what it expects of you, which helps you become more connected to the kochos of the Rebbe and draw down strength to do your shlichus. "This is the way of the Rebbe our Nasi – he gives strength and ability to whoever accepts this shlichus... they will surely be successful."

Think about where you want to be when Moshiach comes and fundraise accordingly.

Habit 3 Put First Things First

Putting first things first recognizes that the challenge is not to manage time, but to manage self. The secret to effective personal management and long term fundraising success is to focus most of your time on activities which are important but not urgent, such as crisis prevention, relationship building, scouting new opportunities, and planning.

To do this, you have to recognize that not doing everything that comes along is okay. Concentrate on your highest prior-



ities. What are "first things"? First things are those things you, personally, find most worthwhile. These priorities must be organized according to the personal mission you established in Habit 2.

Exponential fundraising growth is the result of effective management of self through delegation of time (efficiency) and people (effectiveness). Many refuse to delegate to others, contending that it is too time consuming or "I can do it better by myself".

Yet in reality, delegating to others stands as perhaps the single most powerful high-leverage activity there is. Delegation means growth for the individual and the organization. The Rebbe made use of this technique and empowered the shluchim to delegate via the principle of shliach oseh shliach. Delegating the task of fundraising beholds the secret to growing your Chabad house and fulfilling your mission. It is the link between interdependence and the formation of solid relationships.

Habit 4 Think Win/Win

Win-win is a state of mind and heart that seeks mutual benefit in all human interactions. It abandons dichotomies of strong or weak, hard-

ball or softball, win or lose. Win-win sees life as a cooperative arena and believes that there is plenty for everybody, because Hashem is infinite.

Fundraisers have a sustained task of raising funds to accomplish certain goals. But fundraising with a win-win mentality requires the conviction that "to meet the demands of me I must include others in my plans." Just as G-d invited us to be partners in creation to complete the world, we have unfinished goals and we seek others to join us in a collective ambition to complete them.

Fundraising isn't just about filling a gap in my budget; it is also about filling a gap in the donor's desire to give. Every individual has a reason for giving. As Rabbi Herson explains, "People give money for a cause if it is personal to them, if it is something they care about. If it is not in the cause, then it's the relationship that solicits the contribution. Chemistry between shliach and donor is critical to distribution of money."

In this vein, Rabbi Sherman relates that he once received a check for more than he asked for. "I realized that I underestimated the relationship. I undervalued what I represented."

Fundraising, when conducted properly, brings payback for both giver and receiver.

Habit 5 Seek first to understand, then to be understood

Next to physical survival, psychological survival is our greatest need; to be understood, to be affirmed, to be validated, to be appreciated. So if you want to truly be there for your donor, you need to connect to him on a mental and emotional level and learn to listen properly. **Emphatic Listening is the bridge to interpersonal communications.**

If you're like most people, you listen with the intent to reply, not to understand. While the other person is talking, you prepare in your mind what you are going to say and the questions you are going to ask. You filter everything you hear through your life experiences. And consequently, you decide prematurely what the other person means before he or she finishes communicating.

As people give for a multitude of reasons, fundraisers must listen carefully for cues or they will have no idea as to what drives the individual to donate. First understand your donor and the reasons he wants to give. Then seek to be understood and explain your cause.

Habit 6 Synergize

To put it in simple terms, synergy means “two heads are better than one”. The concept is made even stronger with the effect of two Yidden getting together, when you have two of the Nefesh Elohis against one Nefesh Habehamis (this happens because the Nefesh Habehamis will never unite with another; its ego insists on remaining independent, while the Nefesh Elohis yearns to connect with a kindred soul).

Synergy is the habit of creative cooperation. It allows you to discover jointly that which you are much less likely to discover by yourself. You leave a certain comfort zone and confront an entirely new and unknown possibility.

Synergize by valuing differences and recognizing that people see the world not as it is but as they are. Do you wish everyone would just agree with you so

you could all get along? Many people mistake uniformity for unity; sameness for oneness. That's just boring. Differences should be seen as strengths, not weaknesses. They add zest to life.

Rabbi Sherman points out that “today's economic distress can cause potential discomfort among your contributors precisely because they are your friends.” Imagine the predicament of a person who's used to giving generously but can no longer give as much. “That is why it is extremely important to remember that in your role as shliach, it is incumbent upon you to move them forward.” Offer support while continuing to demand of them, like the Rebbe always did. Remember that one must still give tzedakah even when there's little income. Stay connected and work together to come up with new solutions.

This excitement of moving forward changes the culture to that of productivity and vision. Fundraising from this vantage point is what yields the greatest success.

Habit 7 Sharpen the Saw

Habit 7 preserves and enhances the greatest asset to your organization – you. We are instruments of our own performance, and to be effective we need to recognize the importance of taking time to regularly invest in ourselves and sharpen the saw. This is true in all four dimensions of our nature:

Physical: Exercise

Spiritual: Tefilah, hisbonenus, hiskashrus

Mental: Kvius itim latorah

Social: Farbrengens

Renewal also empowers us to move in an upward spiral of growth and continuous improvements. You can't cut down all the trees in a forest without stopping to sharpen the saw. Fundraising fatigue is a common reality in today's fundraising climate; rejuvenation is the solution.

Sharpen the saw by working diligently on sustaining the relationships between you and your constituents. Sharpen the saw by actively taking time for yourself and your family to stay focused and committed to your mission. Sharpen the saw

by strengthening your hiskashrus with the נשלה, thus galvanizing and invigorating your fundraising and outreach peulos.

In Conclusion:

Since fundraising is the keli through which the principal is distributed to you, it is imperative to raise the level of simcha and bitachon in these trying times (Put First Things First). Don't get caught fundraising for yesterday's bills (Be Proactive); fundraise for tomorrow's goals (Begin with the End in Mind).

Remember that your baalei batim have to know that you hear their pain, especially at a time when many donors complain about their financial difficulties. When you understand their struggle and their positions, only then do you frame your position (Seek First to Understand, Then to Be Understood). Think: What can we do together now? How can we help each other (Think Win-Win)? Let's share the pain together. I will watch my expenses more carefully, and you will step up to the plate (Synergize).

Most importantly, strengthen your hiskashrus to the Rebbe (Sharpen the Saw). הנשיא הוא הכל – שהכל צרכי בני ישראל, הרוחניים והגשמיים, באים ונמשחים ממנו. How much more so is this true for shluchim who dedicate their lives to perpetuating the Rebbe's mission. ☞

המעשה הוא העיקר

- Create your personal mission statement. Print it out, frame it, and hang it in your office.
- Think of a baal habayis in your community and determine how his next contribution will be a win-win situation.
- In your next conversation, practice Emphatic Listening. Try to listen carefully to what the other person is saying (and what they're trying to say), without thinking of your response.